muscular diplomacy and unilateral assertion of India's own goals and bridging the alienation gap at the highest political levels in neighbouring countries, 2) adding momentum to India's development cooperation, 3) initiating further efforts to improve efficient delivery of promised projects, 4) reinforcing the use of soft power and cultural diplomacy, and 5) extending collaboration with extra-regional strategic partners like Japan and the United States to meet the Chinese financial and performance challenge.

To bridge the alienation gap, India has put on back burner its muscular diplomacy, evident at the early stage of the "neighbourhood first" policy. India is now trying to cajole and cultivate regimes in the neighbourhood. In Nepal, setting aside its deep-rooted discomfort with the Communists, India has started adjusting to the Oli regime. After his massive victory in Nepal's general elections, Prime Minister Oli was invited to visit India, where he was offered generous hospitality, and his long list of India's failures in Nepal was listened to without questioning.[21] Being blamed earlier for micro-management and political interference in Nepal, India is keeping a hands-off approach in relation to that country's internal political dynamics. In Sri Lanka, India kept a low profile in the political crisis precipitated by President Sirisena in November 2018 regarding the continuation of the coalition that came to power in 2015 with India's support and encouragement. Ignoring Sirisena's allegations that India's external intelligence agency, the Research and Analysis Wing (RAW), could have been involved in a failed assassination plot against him, India has tried to reach out to all the major stakeholders in Sri Lankan politics, including the ousted Rajapaksa faction of the Sri Lanka Freedom Party (SLFP).[22] India has since softened its approach to the Rajapaksas and welcomed their return to power in 2019. Indeed, both India and the Rajapaksas have come to recognise the value in maintaining mutual